07-03

who was driving the car. Lucy confirmed her mother's suspicion was founded as she answered dejectedly, "I'm sorry to say it was." "Haven't you reported it yet?" asked Jill, Lucy's older sister who was sitting in the passenger seat. "Yes," Lucy replied, lying through her teeth.

07-04

That Lucy should not let the messages get to her and that the sender was only jealous were Lucy's mom's arguments, in an effort to comfort her daughter. Lucy's mom suddenly felt guilty, for she had been the one to buy the phone for Lucy just a couple of months ago. She then admitted her regret about the

07-05

phone was still bugging her out loud as she sighed, "I never should have given you that phone, Lucy." "No, it's fine, I love it," said Lucy knowing that affording the phone had been no small thing for her mother. It had been nothing but trouble though. Lucy did not know who it was that was sending her the messages, and she did not know

07-06

how they had got her number, but whoever it was, he or she had slowly taken over Lucy's life. She was getting several texts a day now, all of which were abusive and hurtful. Lucy wondered what the person who was messaging her might be thinking or trying to achieve with all of their hateful messages. As the car pulled up

07-07

outside the school, which looked like a large shadow in the darkness of a November evening, Lucy felt a shiver run down her spine. Hastened by Jill, who did not want to be late to her own concert, Lucy hesitantly stepped out of the car and walked toward the school. It was Jill who, in her final year of high school, had

07-08

become involved in helping organize this year's school talent show, and she took her position very seriously. Lucy hurried behind Jill pulling on the worn, oversized coat that had originally belonged to Jill, in order to keep her dry as the raindrops fell all around them. As the sisters entered the hall where the show was to

07-09

take place, Jill filled with excitement, while Lucy regretted that she had promised her mother she would participate in the show. "To waste your talent would be a real shame, for you have such a beautiful voice," her mother had argued two months back when the concert was first announced. Lucy had been considering it, for she

07-10

did love to sing. That very night the first text message had come through. "How does it feel to be tall and lanky like a giraffe?" it had asked, taking Lucy by surprise. One of the popular girls, Lucy had always known she wasn't, but before the messages began, Lucy had always been quite

07-11

proud of being a little different. But text-by-text, Lucy's self-confidence had deflated and, in the end, it had taken some doing to get her to agree to perform in the show. Now, however, Lucy had no choice but to make her way towards the stage where Jill was beckoning encouragingly to her. She was the first performer.

07-12

Lucy, announced by her sister to the audience, was all nerves as she walked out onto the middle of the stage where there was nothing but a microphone and her. She heard the audience applaud and could feel a sense of anticipation emanate from the other side of the heavy curtain. As the curtains began to part, she cast a

06-13

"Or notice," Abby said, suddenly feeling like the small, overlooked Mr. Sticky herself and storming from the room. The door to the bedroom opened a few minutes later and Mom's face appeared. She was there to try to make up for having been insensitive earlier. She had put her work on the back burner and occupied

06-14

herself with Sticky. Abby, who was breathing fire all on account of the little snail, tried to ignore her, but it was hard when Mom walked over to the bed and sat next to her. Mom, who Abby still strained to remain upset with, had gone out to find her glasses in order to search for Sticky more effectively.

06-15

"This is my new and extra powerful pair I have for important occasions, like snail hunting," she said. She smiled at Abby, trying to butter her up, but Abby didn't smile back. Abby believed her mom's idea would not succeed, but then she had an idea of her own. "I've got a magnifying

06-16

glass," Abby suddenly remembered and rushed off to find it. On the floor beside each other they sat, shuffling around the tank, looking all over the place and peering into the corners among the big pebbles and the pondweed. Abby tried to imagine, if she were Sticky, a little water snail,

06-17

where would she hide out? At one point she thought she saw him, but it wasn't the water snail. It was a large speck of dust that was deceptively bobbing around in the water, like a live animal. They were ready to call it quits, when suddenly Mom cried, "Ah ha!" Tucked in a curve of the archway,

06-18

perfectly hidden against a pitch dark stone, sat Mr. Sticky, safe and sound. "You, I can always count on," Abby said to her mom, with relief. Then she noticed another water snail was right next to Sticky and asked where this new addition to the family could have come from.

06-19

"I'm beginning to suspect the pond weed is guilty, don't you think?" replied Mom. They both laughed and climbed into Abby's bed together, and though it was cozy, it was a bit of a squeeze. "Budge up," Mom said, giving Abby a push with her bottom.

06-20

"I can't because I'm already on the edge." "Good heavens, you've grown then. When did that happen? You could've put an elephant in here last time we did this. Before I know it, you'll be all grown up." On her mom's chest, Abby then put her head and smiled.

07-01

The text message said that Lucy Josephs was a failure. It said she was ugly, had no style, and the world hated her. At least, that was what it said to Lucy. It said that and a whole lot more that she was struggling to understand. The actual text of the note said that Lucy better not show up at the party tonight because it was going to be

07-02

bad enough already! Lucy, who had started receiving these messages a few weeks ago, tapped the mobile screen to make the message disappear from view. She only wished it was as easy to tap her heart and erase the trace the message had left there. "Was that another one of those messages?" her mom asked,

06-03

gravel. At school that day, Abby, encouraged by her teacher, wrote excitedly about the small and mysterious Mr. Sticky who you could mistake for a piece of gravel. He seemed an ideal pet for her - some of the girls in her class teased - because Abby was also very small.

06-04

That evening, Abby turned on the light and found Mr. Sticky clinging to the pondweed and bobbing about in the air bubbles. "That looks fun!" Abby exclaimed. She tried to imagine what it must be like to have to hang on to things all day and decided the answer was that it was probably very tiring. Abby told her Mom that she

06-05

thought Sticky had grown a bit the next day at breakfast. "Just as well if he's going to be gobbled up like that," her Mom responded, who was busy preparing breakfast. Abby whined that she didn't want him to get too big or he wouldn't be cute anymore. "Small things, not big things, are cute, right?"

06-06

she asked, half to herself. The next day in art class, Abby needed two pieces of paper that were very expensive to draw an elephant, but the teacher didn't mind Abby using the expensive paper because she was pleased with the drawing and wanted it on the wall. The teacher, who was always very encouraging, remarked that the drawing Abby had made was

06-07

very creative and beamed at Abby, giving her the seal of approval. Back at home, Mom, convinced by Abby to clean out the tank, was cleaning with a special vacuum, or "hoover." "Where's Mr. Sticky?" Abby asked first thing, when she came home from school.

06-08

"On the side," Mom replied. And then she added, "Don't worry, I went extra slowly since it's better to be safe than sorry." Abby looked on all sides of the tank, but there was no sign of the water snail that she had discovered a couple of days ago. She was very sad.

06-09

Her Mom said to wait a few hours until the water clears to take another careful look. That evening, Abby went up to her bedroom to check the tank again. The water had settled and looked clear, but Abby could not see Mr. Sticky. Abby kneeled down to have another look in the tank

06-10

that her Mom had cleared so thoroughly, but Mr. Sticky was still nowhere to be found. Abby was a bundle of nerves as she descended the stairs. In the study, surrounded by books and papers, her mom was working, and she looked impatient when she saw Abby in the doorway and even more worried when she heard the bad news.

06-11

"He'll turn up," Mom said, and that was that. Then, to add fuel to the flames, she raised her tone of voice and said dismissively, "For the time being, go to bed, Abby. I've got masses of work to catch up on." Abby had a quick temper and she was angry as hell. "You've hoovered him up,

06-12

haven't you?" she said accusingly. Abby's Mom denied Abby's version of the story was true and said that she was careful, but, because Mr. Sticky was so small, he was hard to see. "What's wrong with being small?" "Nothing at all, but it makes things hard to find."